

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Jessica: Today on the Social Radars, we're joined by Paul Graham, founder my cofounder at Y
(00:00:00) Combinator. Welcome, Paul. Welcome, Paul.

Paul: Thank you.
(00:00:10)

Jessica: We are taping this at the Y Combinator Founders Mode retreat. No kidding. You're
(00:00:10)

Carolynn: Wow. The sarcasm.
(00:00:18)

Jessica: Oh, it's starting now.
(00:00:18)

Carolynn: No. No.
(00:00:19)

Jessica: Okay. So let's think back last year to Brian Chesky's talk.
(00:00:20)

Paul: Yeah.
(00:00:25)

Jessica: That was incredible, and everyone in that room was affected. Do you remember that
(00:00:26) talk?

Paul: Well, everyone who saw that will remember that talk. Yeah. Yeah. Default reaction to
(00:00:32) that talk is it's the best talk I've ever heard. You know?

And we gave a talk this year too. I said upfront that having been the best talk ever, there's no way we could possibly reproduce it. So we just talked about the talk largely because it was this unique one off. It was unique product of the circumstances. Right?

Like, Brian, I don't know how much he told you. He wasn't even supposed to be speaking. Right? But Ron Conway nagged him to come, he's like, alright. Alright.

I'll come. Yeah. Right? And then he wasn't even on the schedule. You know, and Garry just said, you know, get up and say a few words.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

He went off for, like, over an hour Yeah. And the audience was sitting there the entire time because he was talking I mean, it's the a unique circumstance. He was talking about something that they had all experienced and felt like it was only them.

Jessica:
[\(00:01:33\)](#)

Paul:
[\(00:01:34\)](#) So there were really two parts to the whole founder mode phenomenon. Right? There was his talk, which by itself would have just been a Founder telling their story, which are often dramatic. But then afterwards, I talked to all the founders, you know, because it's this big event with huge number of founders, and everyone, one after another, said, the same thing happened to me. I had no idea.

Then I knew something was going on. Right? That every single person had been suffering in secret from the things Brian had been suffering from and trying to solve the same problems. That's how I knew you know, there was something missing in the world. There was this thing they could be doing.

It was like when they would discover planets by their gravitational effects before they could actually observe them. They sort of knew that there was a planet out there, right, because they could detect its secondary effects, and they just had to go look for the planet. So this reaction of everyone was like the evidence there was a planet out there, and the planet is Founder Mode. Yeah. Right?

And so now the task is figure out what it is, and that might sound it might sound like we're being sort of bogus. We're talking about this thing, we don't know what it is, but it's not bogus because we know we can describe what it is. It is all the things that you can do if you're the founder of the company that you could you couldn't do if you were just a hired manager. Right? Right.

We don't know what all those things are, just like you can detect. There's totally a planet here for sure. I'll bet my life on it. Look at the gravitational effects. We still haven't observed it.

Right? And so or in math, there's all sorts of sets that are precisely described, but we definitely don't know what all the members of the sets are. There's a lot of math papers to be written about that. And so that's what we're doing now. We're like writing the papers describing the set of things in Founder Mode.

Jessica:
[\(00:03:20\)](#) Tell us about your essay Founder Mode.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul: Okay. So after Brian gave this talk, I thought the essay is really a call for people to figure out what this thing is. Right? Like, the essay was essentially saying, we know there's this planet out there. We're not sure what it is.

[\(00:03:23\)](#)

I'm not I deliberately tried to say as little specific about what it meant in the essay, just the general description like I gave you. Right. And so the essay was a call for people to like, a, wake up to the existence of this thing. You don't have to do what your c level execs tell you. Right?

And also figure out what it is. Tell us, you know, tell one another, tell us, try things, see what seems to work. I'm sure even now, even if you collected everyone's experiences about stuff that they could do as founders, it still wouldn't be a complete list. Yeah. Because people have explored such a small subset of how to operate companies.

Everybody just does the standard things. They're afraid to do anything weird. Right? Plus the world's changing fast because of AI. So even if there's so much more to be discovered about it.

Jessica: In the past couple days, we've been talking to founders about what founder mode means to them and hearing different stories. So we're finding some themes Yeah. But different examples.

[\(00:04:27\)](#)

Paul: That's the whole point.

[\(00:04:38\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah.

[\(00:04:39\)](#)

Paul: Yeah. The theme is what we figured out in the beginning. The examples, we'll still be figuring out ten years from now.

[\(00:04:39\)](#)

Jessica: One thing that really struck me in his talk was how people sort of accused him of micromanaging when he was really just trying to understand what was happening with the project. Maybe we

[\(00:04:44\)](#)

Carolynn: Need to destigmatize the word micromanaging. Maybe micromanaging is not

[\(00:04:56\)](#)

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul:
[\(00:05:01\)](#) Such a thing. Right? There is you could probably you could probably figure out how to define what's going too far because for sure there's going too far. For example, one thing we know is going too far is when you make someone do their job worse.

Carolynn:
[\(00:05:15\)](#) That's yes. That's true.

Paul:
[\(00:05:17\)](#) That's true. If you measure by results, and that's certainly possible to do. If you don't know something and somebody else is an expert and you get in there and say and you know where this is a classic case? Graphic design. There's this I saw this graphic design firm had, like, their prices listed and they had, you let us do everything and there was this comparatively low price.

You get involved in the designs and there's this much higher price. Right? Like, you control everything. There's this infinitely higher price. Or there's a there's a joke in or not a joke, a rule of thumb in the world of advertising.

Like, never let the never let the customer be in the ads. Not the client.

Jessica:
[\(00:05:54\)](#) The client.

Paul:
[\(00:05:55\)](#) Right? Yeah. Because they think they're an actor, and they're just not. And they're not. You know?

Yeah. So there's you can definitely make things worse.

Carolynn:
[\(00:06:02\)](#) Well yeah. And Brian did say. He's like when he talks to people, it's like, you're actually I've done this before. You're actually better at it than I am, but I collaborate still with you, but you're actually the expert. He did say something like that, so you're right.

Paul:
[\(00:06:16\)](#) Steve Jobs is notoriously picky. Right? Somehow, he had this long relationship with Johnny Ive where they made amazing things together. There must be an ex I mean, anybody was gonna be accused of micromanaging someone, it would be Steve Jobs, and yet somehow Johnny Ive, who's this brilliant designer, didn't mind it. He seemed to have loved working with Steve, and so there is an example of the other side.

Right? You could see something's micromanaging if the results are worse. You can see that that whatever it was not micromanaging. So you're kinda narrowing it down. Right?

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

But maybe it's possible. Maybe I should sit down and think if you could just define in a sentence what's the difference between micromanaging and not.

Jessica:
[\(00:06:55\)](#) When Johnny and I was speaking at the conference the other night, didn't someone say why didn't it did Steve not bug you? Why did you enjoy working with him? What was his answer?

Carolynn:
[\(00:07:06\)](#) Yeah. He someone didn't someone did ask that.

Jessica:
[\(00:07:08\)](#) Someone asked came up. Garry probably asked.

Paul:
[\(00:07:11\)](#) Okay.

Jessica:
[\(00:07:11\)](#) And didn't he say no because he was part He was collaborating. Collaborating So with

Paul:
[\(00:07:17\)](#) Maybe this is the thing. If the person you if the boss if the person who's not the boss, the person who works for the boss, if they feel like it's collaboration, a then it's not micromanaging. Yeah. Maybe.

Jessica:
[\(00:07:27\)](#) Yes. Which is what Brian said in his talk last night. You have to partner with people. Yeah. You're not micromanaging.

You're partnered with them.

Paul:
[\(00:07:35\)](#) Okay. So we're figuring something out here. Yes. It's it's gotta feel to both parties like a collaboration. We're rebranding micromanaging.

Consensual.

Carolynn:
[\(00:07:44\)](#) Yes. There you go. Somehow, it's gotten a little weird.

Jessica:
[\(00:07:49\)](#) It's just such an important topic, and I feel like it resonates with so many people. Just out of curiosity, because we haven't we've been so busy. We haven't even huddled and talked about our time at this conference. Have you been having a fun time talking to the founders, and what are things are you learning from the people here?

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul:
[\(00:08:08\)](#) Well, one of the most exciting things I just learned is that vibe coding is a real thing. Because I was sorta little worried that vibe coding might be a fad. Right? It's just the sort of thing that would be a fad. People would want it to work.

It's the kind of thing people would try for a long time and they go, it never works well. I talked to a startup that works on the back end stuff used by all the vibe coders and old fashioned hand coders, and so they know how much money all these apps are making. The vibe coding apps are making a lot of money. Really? If they're making a lot of money, that's the test of whether people will keep doing it or not.

News flash, we know for sure vibe coding is real. And this is fresh news because this guy himself said if I'd asked him six months ago, he wouldn't have been able to say for sure, but he just felt like he had enough data now to say, okay. This is really gonna stick.

Jessica:
[\(00:09:01\)](#) Will you tell our audience what vibe coding is?

Paul:
[\(00:09:04\)](#) Vibe coding is where you tell an AI to write the code for you.

Jessica:
[\(00:09:09\)](#) Well, wait.

Paul:
[\(00:09:09\)](#) And speaking You're not even a programmer. You just tell it in English.

Carolynn:
[\(00:09:12\)](#) Speaking of naming conventions, you said hand coding. Is that was that what we're gonna stick with in terms of what is the opposite? That up. Yeah. I was gonna say, but what is the right word for people who can actually code without using AI?

Paul:
[\(00:09:27\)](#) You know, it'll probably later one day, maybe it'll have some name like Legacy Coding or something.

Carolynn:
[\(00:09:33\)](#) Legacy Coding. Yeah. Probably.

Paul:
[\(00:09:34\)](#) Which would be horrible because now I'm a legacy coder if that's true. Oh, no. I'm definitely not gonna be writing any programs by telling AI what to do. I like writing code. I like writing code.

You like it. I enjoy it.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Jessica:
[\(00:09:45\)](#)

Okay.

Paul:
[\(00:09:46\)](#)

I remember from Replit, who's like the big vibe coding company. Yeah. Remember he gave me a very early demo when they weren't even sure that they were gonna do this. It was just this experiment, and I was looking at all this code being churned out by this thing, sort of slightly nauseated. Right?

Like, right? It's just and said, don't look at that. That's object code. This is the source code in English. Right?

And you guys, if any programmer, like, holy shit. But yeah. Right. I know. Source code is like what this means, source code is your in the old world, source code is your program.

Object code is what the compiler spits out, the machine language that you never ever look at. It's considered bad form to go and look at it unless you're doing some weird optimization. Right? And so he's saying that thing that you're thinking of is the source code, is the program. It's not the program anymore.

This is the compiler spewing stuff out. That thing in English over there, that's the program. Interesting. I was really weirded out, but Yeah. That turned out to be the first sign of, a huge, you know, mountain.

Jessica:
[\(00:10:52\)](#)

Yeah. Wow. What else? What else have you gleaned? I'm I'm genuinely curious.

Paul:
[\(00:11:00\)](#)

Stoke is amazing.

Jessica:
[\(00:11:02\)](#)

Oh, we interviewed them yesterday.

Carolynn:
[\(00:11:04\)](#)

Andy. Yeah.

Paul:
[\(00:11:05\)](#)

Why aren't you amazing?

Carolynn:
[\(00:11:06\)](#)

Favorite companies. He's so low key. Andy's so low key, but that is an amazing company.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul:
[\(00:11:12\)](#) They're just going to take over the world. They're so good at engineering. I actually flew up to visit them a couple years ago, and he's just delivered ever since. He never misses deadlines. He's just like this execution machine.

I don't think he even realizes himself what an ass kicking founder he is because he's just in the rocket business. Up there and, you know, he's not in Silicon Valley meeting all these other founders all the time. He's off in some test range making rockets take off. Right?

Jessica:
[\(00:11:40\)](#) He told us that all the things that you saw a few years ago are totally different now.

Carolynn:
[\(00:11:46\)](#) Oh, yeah.

Paul:
[\(00:11:46\)](#) I wouldn't be surprised. Yeah.

Jessica:
[\(00:11:48\)](#) And we should go again.

Paul:
[\(00:11:49\)](#) Okay.

Jessica:
[\(00:11:50\)](#) And I wanna come this time.

Paul:
[\(00:11:51\)](#) Really? I would be I'm always psyched to go visit places like that.

Jessica:
[\(00:11:55\)](#) What else? What else?

Paul:
[\(00:11:57\)](#) I was surprised what a variety of things people are working on.

Jessica:
[\(00:12:02\)](#) Oh, really?

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul: I was just this morning, I was talking to a guy who, like, cap does carbon capture off of locomotives.
[\(00:12:02\)](#)

Jessica: Nope. That's Paul. That's Paul.
[\(00:12:09\)](#)

Paul: Yeah. Paul, you know,
[\(00:12:11\)](#)

Jessica: We interviewed him yesterday. Okay.
[\(00:12:12\)](#)

Carolynn: That's great.
[\(00:12:14\)](#)

Jessica: Is this is not planned, by the way. Yeah. We were, like, referencing all these people that we did these short Founder Mode clips with.
[\(00:12:15\)](#)

Paul: Okay.
[\(00:12:23\)](#)

Carolynn: Talk about by the way, you must have noticed what a cheerful guy Paul is.
[\(00:12:23\)](#)

Paul: And, also, believe it or not, even though he's quite far along, I had an idea for something he could do. I was like, you know what you should do? And he said,
[\(00:12:27\)](#)

Carolynn: Oh, wow. That's an interesting idea. You know what you should do. The finger wag. The finger wag.
[\(00:12:35\)](#)

Jessica: I am going so off piste, but I have to tell you a story that I just learned half an hour ago. Apparently so for our listeners, we're at this retreat right now off-site with the YC founders, and our sons are here with us. Not participating in the conference, but they're milling around. And last night, there was there was some of the founders gathered at the bar, and one of the security people came up to one of the, women running the conference and said, excuse me. I think we have a problem.
[\(00:12:40\)](#)

I think Paul and Jessica's son is drinking, because our son's 16. 16. And it was Paul Gross because he looks so young Oh my from Remora.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul: They thought he was
[\(00:13:25\)](#)

Carolynn: That that was our son, and he
[\(00:13:26\)](#)

Paul: Was 28.
[\(00:13:27\)](#)

Carolynn: He's 28. Yeah. Exactly. Which He does
[\(00:13:28\)](#)

Paul: Look young.
[\(00:13:30\)](#)

Carolynn: He does. He has a baby face.
[\(00:13:31\)](#)

Paul: Well, was because some of the founders are so young and old people they talk to, like VCs and people running train networks, just don't trust anyone that young. We've heard founders talk about tricks they use to seem older. Do you remember there were those guys who said they wear wristwatches? Because no one young wears a wristwatch. Oh, if you wear a wristwatch, we're all wearing watches?

Not you. You're young, C. Levy.

Carolynn: No. I'm not young. I just don't wear a watch.
[\(00:13:59\)](#)

Paul: You have some sort of earphone that, like, broadcast the time to you every minute.
[\(00:14:01\)](#) Right? In your ear.

Carolynn: Like that. But I did.
[\(00:14:07\)](#)

Paul: I That would be a menace. That would be dystopian.
[\(00:14:08\)](#)

Jessica: Yes. It would be. Yes. It would be. By the way, Paul Gross did tell us a trick that he did use when people were skeptical about his age.
[\(00:14:11\)](#)

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

He does extremely deep dives into information and says, I'm gonna know more about what this is I'm talking to you about than you do.

Carolynn: Yeah. Like, you can't be stumped.
[\(00:14:28\)](#)

Paul: Yeah. So I think I was talking to him about this. He said people think he's too young when they first meet him, but after ten minutes, they think, well, this kid seems to know his stuff. Exactly.

Jessica: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Exactly. So any last thoughts on the Founder Mode retreat before we wrap up?
[\(00:14:38\)](#)

Paul: We still have to figure out more. Yeah. We're getting we're collecting a lot of stories about what it is, but we still need to collect more. Founders seem really happy.
[\(00:14:45\)](#)

Carolynn: They also
[\(00:14:54\)](#)

Paul: Seem Obviously, it's a good not just because it's a good retreat. I think in general, things are going well for a lot of people's companies. This is not things are it's a happy time in the startup world right now And having been through a few cycles We've all been through some I can appreciate happy times. Let's hope tariffs don't bring everything crashing down.
[\(00:14:54\)](#)

Carolynn: I was I asked someone about tariffs yesterday. I don't I don't remember.
[\(00:15:17\)](#)

Paul: Well, there's Paul.
[\(00:15:21\)](#)

Carolynn: It was Paul.
[\(00:15:22\)](#)

Paul: If there's some macroeconomic thing, like the stock market crashes and everything goes to hell globally, that always affects startups.
[\(00:15:23\)](#)

Jessica: You know? Does.
[\(00:15:30\)](#)

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator Released August 22, 2025

Paul:
[\(00:15:30\)](#) Venture funding dries up. And so it's weird. Like, we've simultaneously got if you looked at if you looked at a bunch of startups in California, you'd think things have never been better. And if you looked at what's happening in Washington DC with, like, everything getting torn down left and right by this blonde Godzilla, you know, it would seem like things have never been worse. Which prevails?

I honestly don't know. Should I be optimistic or depressed?

Jessica:
[\(00:15:53\)](#) That's a good question. Can we end by you sharing your you gave a you told me about a great metaphor the other day about as we collect data on Founder Mode, we're sort of discovering the edges and plotting

Paul:
[\(00:16:06\)](#) Oh, it was an island.

Jessica:
[\(00:16:07\)](#) An island.

Paul:
[\(00:16:08\)](#) Yes. We knew that there was an island at such and such location. Right? But we don't know what the coastline looks like. We don't know how far you can get to the edge before you hit sea.

Right? C being actually micromanaging people or something like that. Yeah. Right? So it'll take a while.

It'll take a while, but no one is in a better position to figure this out than YC because YC has this huge collection of founders. There's a huge number of founders, and they're totally willing to talk candidly because they all trust one another. You know? And that combination is unbeatable. No one's in a better position to figure this out.

Jessica:
[\(00:16:41\)](#) Yeah. Alright. I think that's a great place to end, and, hopefully, we'll keep working on figuring it out.

Paul:
[\(00:16:47\)](#) I'm interested.

Carolynn:
[\(00:16:48\)](#) Thanks, Paul. Thanks, Paul.

Paul:
[\(00:16:49\)](#) Thanks for having me, guys.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator
Released August 22, 2025

Jessica: Bye. Bye.
[\(00:16:50\)](#)